



RED ALERT: (clockwise from left) Lal Masjid; an army vehicle moves towards the mosque; Ghazi, the hardline cleric who died; Musharraf



killed eight policemen and left the tent-housed offices of two aid agencies in flames were only a warning of things to come. Baitullah Mahsud, a key Pakistani Taliban leader based in the tribal area of South Waziristan, has reportedly sworn to avenge the mosque killings. Other "ungoverned spaces", particularly in the tribal areas, may step up their 'revenge' actions, intelligence sources say. The killing of Chinese mechanics last week near Peshawar, providing repair backup to Chinese tri-wheelers, was a crude retaliation to the way the security forces had snubbed the Lal Masjid vigilantes

for abducting some Chinese masseurs in Islamabad in the last week of June.

As the shadows of rightwing show-down with the military grow, an ambitious Benazir Bhutto, who has been negotiating a comeback with Musharraf behind closed doors, has defended the army action, saying that the President made the right decision. "I'm glad there was no ceasefire with the militants," she said in a statement. "There will be a backlash, but some time we have to stop appeasing the militants. We can't afford to keep appeasing them," she was quoted as saying in the Urdu-language daily *Aaj*. Her statement, apparently a message to her Washington backers, may have pleased Musharraf, but annoyed the religious leadership that her party has been courting in a bid to enhance its bargaining position with the military.

The raid has at least partly eased a campaign supported by Bhutto's secular, pro-democracy PPP to unseat Musharraf over his suspension of the

country's chief justice in March. "There is clear evidence from the military operation that the Government is very serious about preventing 'Talibanisation' of the country," says Chaudhry Shujaat Hussain, chief of the ruling Pakistan Muslim League. But the raid has merely added to Islamic hardliner's perceptions that Musharraf is a US stooge. "If Musharraf can demolish masjids and madrassas to please the American infidels, all madrasa students, clerics and even moderate Muslims should take to the streets and demolish his dictatorship," said Qari Sher Afzal, a senior MMA leader.

While the media in Pakistan praised the Government for the action, the powerful clergy represented by Wafaqul Madaris of the Deobandi school of thought decided to withdraw their otherwise cooperative liaison with the Musharraf Government. The delegation of clerics led by the old Taliban admirer Maulana Rafi Usmani of Darul Uloom Karachi announced that it was